



CHECKLIST

Are you a carer for someone living with pain? Do you want to learn more about their opioid pain medication?

Questions to ask the doctor or pharmacist

If you're a carer for someone living with pain or someone who takes pain medication, it's important to find out if their medicines contain opioids. Opioids are powerful medicines. Strong and effective when used as directed by the doctor ([see Factsheet 1](#)). But, they can

come with a risk of harm including side-effects or even dependence (see [Factsheet 2](#)).

The doctor or pharmacist should be happy to answer any questions you may have about opioids. Below are some suggestions to help you during these conversations. Feel free to add more if you or the person you care for have other questions.

CHECKLIST

Are you a carer for someone living with pain?

Do you want to learn more about their opioid pain medication?

	Question	Follow Up Questions	Notes
1	The person I'm a carer for takes strong pain medication – is it an opioid?	Are there other medicines that should NOT be taken while using the opioid? (including over-the-counter medicines)	
2	How can I support the person I'm caring for to take their opioid medicines safely?	How much of the medicine should they take and in what form? How often do they need to take the medication? How long should they take it for?	
3	What are the potential side effects or danger signs of taking opioids?	What should I do if the person I'm caring for experiences side effects or I see danger signs?	
4	How do I talk to the person I'm caring for about the risks or concerns I might have about their medication?	I'm worried the person I'm caring for is not taking opioids correctly. How can I talk to them about this or is there someone who can help?	
5	Where can I find more information about opioid medicines?	Is there an information leaflet available?	
6	Are there other medicine options to reduce pain that don't contain opioids?	Are there non-medication options, e.g. lifestyle changes, massage etc	
7	What could happen if the person I'm caring for suddenly stops taking their opioids?	When should they stop their opioid medication?	
8	Is there anyone who can offer me any advice or support to look after myself while caring for someone living with pain or using pain medications?	How do I manage my own wellbeing?	

CHECKLIST

Are you a carer for someone living with pain?
Do you want to learn more about their opioid pain medication?

Factsheets available from Carers Australia:

- [Factsheet 1: How do I know if the person I'm caring for is taking opioid medicines?](#)
- [Factsheet 2: How can I support the person I'm caring for take their opioid medicines?](#)
- [Factsheet 3: What can I do if the person I'm caring for is not using their opioid medicines safely?](#)
- [Factsheet 4: Will the person I'm caring for still have access to opioid medicines?](#)
- [Factsheet 5: How can I help someone living with pain?](#)

The above factsheets can be found at

<https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/opioids-information/caring-for-someone-living-with-pain>.

More resources that may help carers of people taking pain medicines can be found on these websites:

- **Carer Gateway at**
<https://www.carergateway.gov.au/help-advice/working-health-services>
- **Carer Help**
 - Question Prompt List at**
<https://www.carerhelp.com.au/Portals/16/Documents/Carersheet/Question prompt list.pdf>
 - Handling Medications at**
<https://www.carerhelp.com.au/Portals/16/Documents/Carersheet/Medication template%26 handling medications.pdf>
- **NPS MedicineWise at**
<https://www.nps.org.au/>
- **Pain Australia at**
<https://www.painaustralia.org.au/>
- **National Pain Week at**
<http://www.nationalpainweek.org.au/>
- **Australian Pain Management Association at**
<https://www.painmanagement.org.au/>
- **Chronic Pain Australia at**
<http://chronicpainaustralia.org.au/index.php>
- **Palliative Care Australia (Questions PDF) at**
https://palliativecare.org.au/wp-content/uploads/2015/05/PCA002_Asking-Questions-Can-Help_FA.pdf
- **HealthDirect (Question Builder) at**
<https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/question-builder>
- **Think Patient Think Carer (NSW Health PDF) at**
<https://www.nslhd.health.nsw.gov.au/carers/documents/NS11895-E GP Guide - Think Patient - Think Carer.pdf>



FACT SHEET 1

How do I know if the person I'm caring for is taking opioid medicines?

The use of opioid medicines has been increasing in Australia.

Opioid medicines are the strongest medicines you can get to relieve pain. They can be prescribed following a surgery or injury, for specific medical conditions, as well as in cancer treatment and palliative (end of life) care.

Opioids are powerful medicines, so it's important to know if the person you're caring for is taking them. This way you can **support them to take their medicines safely** ([see Factsheet 2](#)).

Opioid medicines are only available with a prescription. You can't buy them over the counter from a pharmacy. There have been some recent changes to the way people can get their opioid medicines in Australia. You can read more about those changes in [Factsheet 4: Will the person I'm caring for still have access to opioid medicines?](#)

While the doctor or pharmacist will usually explain that the prescribed pain medicine contains opioids, research shows that many people are taking opioids without realising.

Because of this, people may take opioids in an unsafe way without understanding the consequences.

Here are 4 ways you can find out if the person you're caring for is taking opioid medicines.



1. Ask the person you're caring for

As a carer, you'll usually know if the person you are caring for is taking pain medication. But, you may not know if their medication contains opioids. It's good to find out then you can help them take their medications safely and avoid any risks.

If you don't know whether the person you're caring for is taking medications, ask them. They may not know if their medicine contains opioids as these are often described by the ingredient. See point number 2.



2. Check the ingredients

There are many different brand names for various opioid medicines. It's best to check the packet for the 'active ingredient'.

If the medicine contains one of the following active ingredients, it will be classed as opioid medicine.

1. Fentanyl
2. Buprenorphine
3. Hydromorphone
4. Methadone
5. Oxycodone
6. Morphine
7. Pethidine
8. Tapentadol
9. Tramadol
10. Codeine

You can read more about these different ingredients on the [Healthdirect](#) website or the NPS MedicineWise [Medicine Finder](#).

Opioid medicines can come in different forms, but they are usually tablets or skin patches.



3. Ask the doctor or pharmacist

You can be a great support for the person you care for by attending doctors' appointments and pharmacy visits with them.

The person you care for has the right to ask the doctor or pharmacist about the medicines they have been prescribed. Talk to them about whether the medicines contain opioids, and what any side effects and risks might be.

You can also ask about the best way to **support the person you care for to take their opioid medicines safely** ([see factsheet 2](#)).



4. Reach out

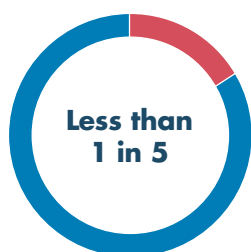
Remember to seek support if you have any questions about opioid medicines.

Call the Medicines Line (1300 633 424) or speak to your pharmacist. They are trained health professionals who can answer your questions and make sure you have the information you need. There is no question too big or small!

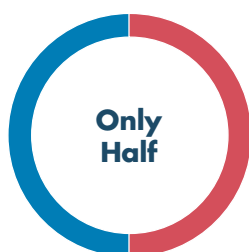
It's important you feel comfortable, so you can support the person you care for to take their opioid medicines safely.

Confused about opioids?

A recent study in Australia showed there's a lack of knowledge about opioids:



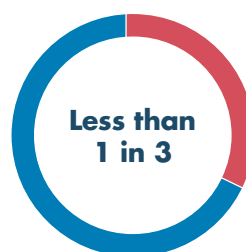
Less than 1 in 5 people using opioids take them in a safe and effective way.



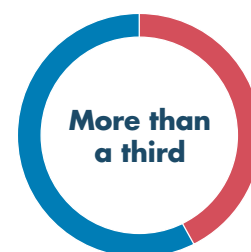
Only half of current opioid users knew they were taking an opioid medication.



Less than half knew all of their current opioid medications were opioids.



Less than 1 in 3 people look for information about opioids after they are prescribed.



More than a third of Australians do not know what opioids are.

Taking opioids safely

Opioids are generally prescribed with information about safe and effective use. As a carer, you may already know how much and when the person you're caring for should be taking their opioids. If you're unsure, it's worth checking in.

Consumer Medicines Information (CMI) leaflets are good sources of information for each medicine. Ask for one from the treating doctor or pharmacist or by using the NPS Medicine Wise Medicine Finder at <https://www.nps.org.au/medicine-finder>.

You may find that the person you're caring for is getting good pain relief with opioids. However, it's important to know that an individual may get used to opioids if taken over a long time. If this happens, they can feel the need to take more and more to get the same pain relief first experienced. Taking higher doses can cause dependence and addiction.

If you're not sure whether the person you're caring for is using opioids safely, find out some of the signs in [Factsheet 3: How can I identify if a person I'm caring for is not using their opioid medicines safely?](#)

Keep talking to the person you care for about their pain. There may be other options to relieve pain. Look at the Health Direct website for more information: <https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/options-for-managing-chronic-pain>

Remember! Seek support from your doctor or pharmacist if you have any questions about how to help someone take their opioid medicines.

Visit the Carer Gateway website at <https://www.carergateway.gov.au/help-advice> or call them on 1800 422 737 to find local services and support for carers.

All factsheets referenced above can be found at <https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/opioids-information/caring-for-someone-living-with-pain>.



FACT SHEET 2

How can I support the person I'm caring for with taking their opioid medicines?

Strong medications such as opioid medicines may be needed by people to relieve pain for a range of reasons. Sometimes people don't understand the risks involved in taking opioid medicines. Less than 1 in 5 people using these medicines take them in a safe and effective way.

With the right information you can support someone to take their opioid medicines safely. To start, it's important to know if the person you care for is taking opioid medicines. If you're not sure whether they're taking opioids, find out more in [Factsheet 1: How do I know if the person I'm caring for is taking opioid medicines?](#)

If the person you're caring for is interested in other ways of reducing pain, find out more on the Carers Australia opioid information webpage at <https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/opioids-information/caring-for-someone-living-with-pain/>

Alternatively, more tips for carers and people with pain can be found here:

- National Pain Week at <http://www.nationalpainweek.org.au/>
- Australian Pain Management Association at <https://www.painmanagement.org.au/>
- Chronic Pain Australia at <http://chronicpainaustralia.org.au/index.php>
- Pain Australia at <http://www.painaustralia.org.au/>

Here are 3 ways you can support the person you're caring for to take their opioid medicines.



1. Understand their medicine.

You'll find that opioid medicines come with an information sheet called a Consumer Medicine Information (CMI) leaflet. It's usually provided by the pharmacist giving the medicines. If you weren't given one of these, ask the pharmacist or look it up online with the NPS MedicineWise Medicine Finder at <http://nps.org.au/medicine-finder>.

The medicine packet will have directions on the correct amount to take and how to store the medicines. The doctor will also have given instructions on how much medicine to take and when.

Knowing the right amount of medicine to be taken each time, and when to take it is really important. If medicines are taken more often than recommended, they can cause an overdose.

Check in regularly with the person you care for to understand how the medication is (or isn't) helping with their pain.

If people continue to take opioid medicines when they are not needed this can cause side-effects or even dependence. Over time people can develop a tolerance to opioid medicines. This may make it seem like the medicines are not working anymore. The person taking the opioids may want to take more to reduce their pain.



2. Know the risks and side effects.

Opioid medicines can cause dependence. They are not recommended for using over a long time except in special circumstances, such as cancer and palliative (end of life) care.

The prescriber or pharmacist will specify the dose and over what time period the medication should be taken for. If opioids are taken over a longer period than prescribed, it can risk health issues or possible overdose. You may need to support the person you care for to be aware of their alcohol and other drug use if they are taking opioid medicines.

If you are worried someone is taking their opioid medicines unsafely (see Factsheet 3), there is support available.

Opioid medicines can result in unwanted side effects. These can include;

- Dizziness
- Nausea
- Vomiting
- Breathing difficulties
- Constipation
- Depression

The information sheet that comes with the opioid medicines will outline how they should be used and any potential side effects.



3. Encourage communication with their doctor or health team.

It can be helpful to attend doctor's appointments with the person you care for. As a carer, you can help by writing down important information that is talked about, in case you need to follow up later. You can also ask the doctor questions to help you better understand the medicine and how to help the person take them safely.

Aside from cancer treatment and palliative care, opioids are usually only prescribed for short periods of time. It's important for the person you care for to be open and honest with their doctor about their pain, and if the opioid medicines are helping or not. This way you can have a conversation about whether opioid medicines are still the right medication to be taking or if there are other options.

Ideally, the person taking opioid medicines will have a pain management plan. This will help you both understand how the use of opioids fits into their plan and what other options there are to manage pain. This plan may include a timeframe to reduce (and eventually stop) the use of opioid medicines. If the person you're caring for does not have a pain management plan, ask for one.

People can become addicted to opioid medicines over time if not used properly. In such a case, it's really important you both talk to the doctor about a safe and supported way to reduce opioid use. This can help to avoid withdrawal symptoms, such as sweating, hot and cold flushes, aches and pains, nausea, and anxiety.

See the Health Direct website for more information.

<https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/opioid-medicines#withdrawal-symptoms>

Keep talking to the person you care for about their pain. There may be other options to relieve pain. Look at the Health Direct website for more information:

<https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/options-for-managing-chronic-pain>

Remember! Seek support from your doctor or pharmacist if you have any questions about how to help someone take their opioid medicines.

Visit the Carer Gateway website at <https://www.carergateway.gov.au/help-advice> or call them on 1800 422 737 to find local services and support for carers.

Check out [Factsheet 3](#) to find out what you can do to help if you feel someone is not using their opioid medicine safely.

All factsheets referenced above can be found at <https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/opioids-information/caring-for-someone-living-with-pain>.



FACT SHEET 3

How can I identify if a person I'm caring for is not using their opioid medicine safely, and what can I do to help?

Opioids are strong and effective pain medicines when used as directed by the doctor. But, opioids can come with a risk of harm, can cause side-effects, increase sensitivity to pain and may be addictive if used long-term.

Find out more about opioids here or if the person you're caring for is taking opioids - [Factsheet 1: How do I know if the person I'm caring for is taking opioid medicines?](#)

Unsafe opioid use

Over the past 10 years in Australia, there has been a significant increase in harm and deaths from the use of opioid medicines. Every day, nearly 150 people are taken to hospital and 14 people admitted to emergency departments because of issues relating to opioid use, and three people die from the harm caused by opioid use. [source: <https://www.tga.gov.au/prescription-opioids-information-consumers-patients-and-carers>.]

The doctor or pharmacist will usually provide information when providing opioids but research shows many people don't realise they're taking opioids. This means people could be using opioids in an unsafe way without knowing.

How to tell if someone is not using opioids safely?

Opioids can be dangerous. If the person you care for is taking opioid medication it's possible they could become dependent without realising it. The body can develop a tolerance which reduces the medication's

effectiveness. That means more and more is needed to get the same pain relief.

If they're not taking the medication correctly there's more possibility of harm. It can be difficult to tell if someone is using their opioid medicines unsafely. Here are some signs to look out for:

Physical signs

- Taking more of the medication than prescribed (a higher dose) or more often
- Taking more medication for non-pain reasons or because it 'makes them feel better'
- Taking the medication in a different way than it's meant to be taken
- Making excuses to get another prescription or seeing another doctor to get extra supplies
- In denial of changes in their behaviour
- Past unsafe use of medications

Psychological signs

- Making poor decisions or changes in mood or behaviour that are unusual for them (e.g. mood swings, being agitated or drowsy after taking their medication)
- Changes in their sleep patterns or being anxious, grouchy or depressed
- The medication is having a negative impact on their life:
 - Avoiding being with friends and family or starting to have trouble with relationships
 - Losing interest in, or experiencing new problems, at school, work or hobbies
 - Taking part in dangerous behaviours unusual for them, such as driving after drinking alcohol
 - Quality of life or living standards deteriorate, e.g. they stop looking after their personal hygiene.

(Adapted from ScriptWise.org.au at <https://www.scriptwise.org.au/prescription-opioids/>)

Things you can do to help

It's natural to worry if the person you care for is not using their medication safely. But it may not be easy to raise it with them. If you are concerned, it is important to reach out to a professional and get advice. It's easier to help someone when you have the support of others.

It's safer to keep medications in a safe, (preferably locked), location, such as a medicine cabinet. This is particularly important if there are children living at the same place.

Start by talking to the doctor or pharmacist about their medication. Find out what the signs are when someone is not taking opioids safely and what your concerns are, for example, they have recently increased their medication, or are using it in a different way.

FACT SHEET 3

How can I identify if a person I'm caring for is not using their opioid medicine safely, and what can I do to help?

Here are some other ways you could help.

- Provide information on the harms and risks to the person you're caring for.
- If you feel comfortable, talk to them about how their behaviour has changed and how it affects others in their life, for example, their kids or loved ones.
- Provide information on specialists who can help, or local support groups. Leave the information lying around if you don't feel confident raising the issue.
- Look into different ways to help manage pain like heat packs, exercise, meditation or massage. Find more options for managing chronic pain on the Health direct website at <https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/options-for-managing-chronic-pain>.

It can take courage to raise the issue of unsafe use of medications with a loved one. If you don't feel comfortable doing so, seek help from the professionals.

If you speak to the one you're caring for, don't be hard on yourself if it wasn't 'heard' the first time. If they're not listening or responding well, take a step back and let the professionals deal with it.

Don't forget your own mental health. Caring for someone who's not taking their opioid medications safely can be emotionally draining. It's important to take good care of yourself.

Visit the Carer Gateway website or call them to find local services and support for you as a carer.

www.carergateway.gov.au | 1800 422 737

The Carer Gateway makes it easier for you to find help, from counselling and peer support to respite care, home help and equipment.

Remember! You can seek support from your doctor or pharmacist if you have any questions about how to help someone take their opioid medicines.

Alternatively, you can get more information for the person you're caring for, about taking opioids safely, by calling Medicine Line:

Call 1300 633 424 (1300 MEDICINE) - (Monday-Friday 9-5 AEST).

All factsheets referenced above can be found at <https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/opioids-information/caring-for-someone-living-with-pain>.



FACT SHEET 4

Will the person I'm caring for still have access to opioid medicines?

Opioids can help relieve pain.

Opioids may be effective over short periods. Occasionally they work for longer periods to relieve pain in serious conditions, e.g. cancer. But, generally using opioids over a long time for chronic non-cancer pain can risk harm and can be addictive.

If you're caring for someone who takes opioids, you can help by understanding how to use opioids safely. See [Factsheet 3: How can I identify if a person I'm caring for is not using their opioid medicines safely?](#)

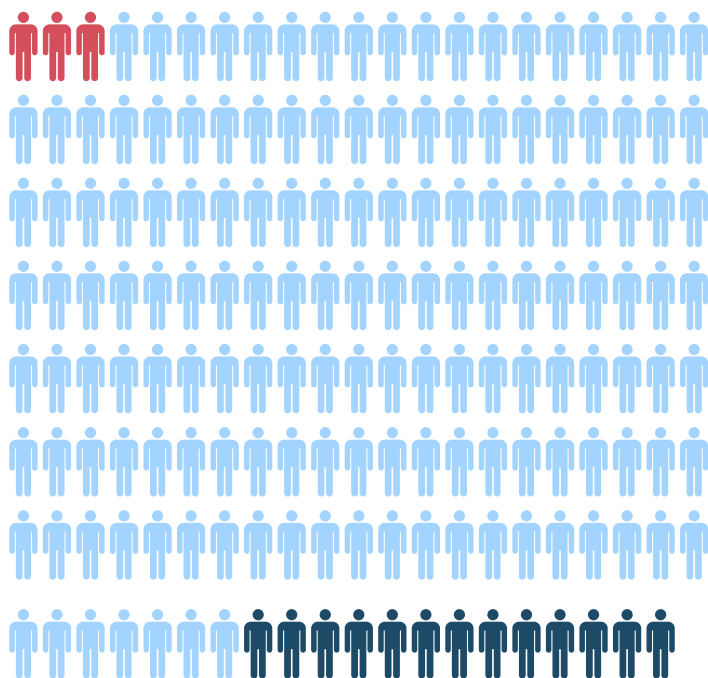
Prescriptions for opioid medications

Due to the risk of harm and possible addiction, opioids are no longer available 'over the counter' in a pharmacy. They're only available with a prescription from a doctor who will explain how long it's safe to take opioids and how to avoid unsafe use.

The doctor will make sure they fully understand a person's medical history, family and personal situation before prescribing opioids. They'll monitor the use at future appointments. As their carer, it can be useful to go to appointments with the person you're caring for so you can find out more about their medication.

Getting opioids

The Australian Department of Health has introduced new requirements to get opioid medicines. Their role is to protect the public's health and prioritise patient safety. This includes reducing harms associated with inappropriate use of prescription opioids.



Every day in Australia, an average of 3 people die, 150 people are hospitalised and 14 people present to emergency departments because of harm from opioids.

[NPS MedicineWise](#) (2020)

The new requirements aim to cut down on overall opioid use and include:

- Introduction of additional smaller opioid pack sizes,
- Increased restrictions for larger pack sizes,
- Information and clear warnings about potential harm,
- Tightening the conditions to get prescriptions for opioids.

The measures are based on expert advice from specialists in the field of opioid medications (Opioid Regulatory Advisory Group (ORAG).

These changes apply to all opioids. Because of the new requirements, it might seem more difficult for the person you're caring for to get opioid medicines.

What should the person you're caring for know about the changes?

If the person you're caring for uses opioids, they may be worried the changes will stop them from getting their medicines. It won't stop them, but they'll probably notice some changes.

- Experts continue to consider opioids as important and effective medicines in the treatment of short-term pain relief. They continue to monitor the benefits and risks of opioid medicines.
- Changes are being made because harmful use of opioids in Australia has been rising.
- The same opioids are available, but health professionals will now prescribe smaller pack sizes for short-term pain and check updated patient requirements before prescribing.

- Smaller pack sizes reduce the risk of harm from unused opioids.
- Any unused opioids should be returned to a local pharmacy.
- Updated patient criteria will help reduce the unsafe or incorrect use of the most powerful opioids (such as fentanyl).
- People who require long-term pain relief using opioids, such as people with cancer and those receiving palliative (end of life) care, are likely to receive the same opioid medicine and pack size as they did before.
- Stopping opioids suddenly can lead to withdrawal symptoms. People should continue to take their pain medicine but speak with their doctor about alternative options or reducing their dose, in case it's no longer appropriate.

Adapted from NPSMedicine at <https://www.nps.org.au/radar/articles/opioids-new-and-amended-pbs-listings#r15>.

New information on warnings

Healthcare professionals will discuss warnings with patients taking or planning to take opioids. This includes information on the dose, how to take the medicine, how long it should last, and stronger warnings about the risk of dependence and addiction. As their carer it can be useful to be part of these discussions.

Additional warnings will be added to the Consumer Medicine Information (CMI) leaflet to make it clear opioids can cause addiction and withdrawal symptoms if stopped suddenly.

A new warning label will be placed on the packaging of opioid products when given by pharmacists.

If you're caring for someone who uses opioids and you have questions about the medicine or side effects, talk to the person who prescribed the medicine or to a pharmacist.

Remember! Keep talking to the person you care for about their pain. There may be other options to relieve pain.

Options for managing long-term (chronic) pain are available on the Health Direct website at <https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/options-for-managing-chronic-pain>.

All factsheets referenced above can be found at <https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/opioids-information/caring-for-someone-living-with-pain>.



FACT SHEET 5

How can I help someone living with pain?

People who care for a family member or friend living with long-term (chronic) pain play a vital role in making sure their loved one's pain is managed correctly. This helps lead to a better quality of life for the person living with pain.

As a carer you have a unique insight and understanding of what it's like for a person living with pain. This is invaluable as understanding and compassion towards the person is often reported as being one of the things that can help someone manage their condition.

Adapted from Chronic Pain Australia at https://chronicpainaustralia.org.au/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=303.

Take care of yourself

Being in pain has a big impact on a person's quality of life. When someone you care for is living with pain, you can see how it can be exhausting and irritating

for them. But, you shouldn't overlook how caring for someone in pain can be physically taxing and emotionally draining for you too. It's important to take good care of yourself.

Remember you can't be there for someone else unless you first look after yourself.

Find support at Carer Gateway - www.carergateway.gov.au | T: 1800 422 737

If you're a young carer, you can get additional support from www.youngcarersnetwork.com.au.

Being there helps

There are plenty of ways to help someone in pain. Support helps the person you're caring for feel less alone and feel looked after. It can help them feel more able to deal with their symptoms.

10 ways to help someone you care for



1. Ask about their pain

Everyone has a unique, individual experience of pain. You probably already know about their pain but asking how they're going reminds them you care.

- How is your pain today?
- Will your pain affect what you do today?
- What things make it feel worse?
- What things help?



2. Listen and show warmth

It's not easy to understand constant pain unless you've been there. You know their pain is real but don't brush off their pain by saying they'll be fine or it'll pass. It may be well meaning but is unlikely to help. Look at the world from their perspective and appreciate that they're doing their best to get on with their life in the best way they can.



3. Don't define them by the pain

Sometimes people can define themselves by their pain. As their carer it helps to remind them of the rounded human they are and what makes them special.



4. Ask how you can help

Pain symptoms can change day to day so keep checking in. That way you can stay on the same page. Never underestimate how your role as a carer gives them a sense of a normal life. If you've asked your loved one to go to activities or social engagements but they say no, don't let that stop you from asking them again. And again. They still want to have fun too.



5. Use a pain scale

Have a pain scale from 1 to 10.

Ask the person you care for what their level of pain is:

- 1 = free of pain and feeling fabulous
- 5 = having some pain but managing it
- 10 = having the worst pain ever

This'll help you understand how they're feeling and how you can support them.



6. Look for signs of pain

You spend a lot of time with the one you care for and probably know the signs when they're in pain. For example, decreased activity, poor concentration, sleep disturbances, mood swings, moaning, hand wringing, irritability, restlessness and grimacing. But, pain can be mentally tiring too. Keep an eye out for any signs of stress or depression.



7. Respect what they can and can't do

Every day can be different. Someone with pain might be happy to walk somewhere one day or do physical activity, but another day, may struggle to get out of bed. Recognise their physical abilities each day. When the person in pain needs to stop what they're doing to sit down, lie down or go home – go with it without judgement.



8. Offer to go to appointments with them

Going to medical appointments with the person you're caring for, not only helps you understand their condition, it gives you chance to find out more about their medication. Being there helps be their back-up to hear all the information given, and it's an emotional support too. As the carer, it can be helpful to arrange appointments or speak with health professionals, work bosses or colleagues, teachers, family or friends to extend support.



9. Encourage healthy living and positive thinking

It can be easy to slip into unhealthy ways when feeling severe pain. Encouraging the one you love to look after themselves is a really positive thing to do. This might involve:

- planning meals, grocery shopping or cooking healthier food together,
- going for walks or other physical activities together.

Staying positive can help the person you care for feel more positive and help them build confidence and hope. This doesn't mean dismissing their feelings or ignoring their experiences, but gently encouraging positivity when the time is right.



10. Explore various pain relief options

Remember! You may not always be able to help in pain management directly. Sometimes their pain can take a toll on your health as well. Refer to [Factsheet 3](#) for things you can do to help.

Look after yourself too.

Care for yourself and take the time and space you need to recuperate. Support is available for you:

Call Carer Gateway on 1800 422 737 (8am-5pm, Mon-Fri).

More tips for carers and people with pain can be found here:

- National Pain Week at <http://www.nationalpainweek.org.au/>.
- Australian Pain Management Association at <https://www.painmanagement.org.au/>.
- Chronic Pain Australia at <http://chronicpainaustralia.org.au/index.php>.
- Pain Australia at <http://www.painaustralia.org.au/>.

Look out for Chronic Pain apps, blogs and podcasts. It can help the person you're caring for, know they're not alone.

Pain Australia has an excellent directory at www.painaustralia.org.au/getting-help/pain-directory.

Remember! Seek support from your doctor or pharmacist if you have any questions about how to help someone take their opioid medicines.

If you're looking for support as a carer, visit the Carer Gateway website at <https://www.carergateway.gov.au/help-advice> or call them on 1800 422 737 to find local services and support.

All factsheets referenced above can be found at <https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/opioids-information/caring-for-someone-living-with-pain>.